Rebuilding your Outlook profile

Article KB0010065 | Owner: Messaging & Collaboration | Subcategory: Outlook | Applies to: Windows 11 22H2/23H2/24H2 on Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840, macOS 14/15 on MacBook Pro/Air (Outlook for Mac), Microsoft Outlook (part of Microsoft 365) connected to Acme Global Exchange Online

Summary

This article guides users and service-desk agents through rebuilding an Outlook profile to resolve common issues such as missing email, frequent crashes, disconnection, search failures, or repeated password prompts. It includes a self-help procedure for end-users and a detailed agent workflow, followed by verification steps and escalation guidance.

Symptoms

- Outlook shows "Disconnected" or "Trying to connect..." status bar
- No new mail arrives despite server being reachable
- Outlook crashes or stops responding shortly after launch
- Search returns no results or hangs
- Repeated prompts for username/password even after correct credentials are entered
- Error dialog: "Cannot start Microsoft Outlook. Cannot open the Outlook window."
- Error dialog: "Something went wrong. Outlook could not load your profile."

Common causes

- Corrupted Outlook profile (.pst or .ost file) or damaged registry entry
- Faulty COM add-in interfering with Outlook startup
- Out-of-date or corrupted offline address book (OAB) or search index
- Network authentication issues caused by expired or mismatched credentials
- Profile lock due to simultaneous access from multiple devices
- Failed update of Outlook or Windows that left profile settings inconsistent

Overview

An Outlook profile stores your email account settings, data files, and preferences. When the profile becomes corrupted, Outlook may exhibit symptoms such as disconnection, crashes, or repeated credential prompts. Rebuilding the profile creates a fresh set of configuration files while preserving your mailbox data stored on the Exchange server (or in your .ost/.pst if you have a local copy). This procedure is safe for most users and does not delete email, calendar, or contacts unless a local .pst file is specifically removed.

Preliminary Checks

Before rebuilding the profile, verify a few basic items to avoid unnecessary work. Ensure you have network connectivity (can access the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi or VPN). Confirm that you can log into Outlook on the web (https://outlook.office.com) with your Acme credentials; if web access fails, the issue may be network or account related. Disable any recently installed COM add-ins temporarily via Outlook -> File -> Options -> Add-Ins -> Manage COM Add-ins -> Go... and uncheck them, then restart Outlook to see if the problem persists. If the issue disappears, note the offending add-in for later removal or update.

Self-Help Procedure - Rebuild Outlook Profile

Follow these steps to create a new Outlook profile and set it as the default. This works on Windows 10/11 Outlook desktop client. Mac users should use the Outlook for Mac profile manager or contact the Service Desk for assistance.

1. Close Outlook completely. Ensure no Outlook processes remain in Task Manager.
2. Press Win?+?R, type control.exe /name Microsoft.MailAndCalendar, and press Enter to open Mail Setup (alternatively, search for "Mail" in Control Panel).
3. In the Mail Setup dialog, click Show Profiles...
4. Select the existing profile (usually named "Outlook") and click Remove. Confirm the deletion when prompted.
5. Click Add... to create a new profile. Enter a descriptive name (e.g., "Acme-Outlook") and click OK.
6. In the Add Account window, enter your full Acme email address (firstname.lastname@acme.example) and click

Connect. Outlook will attempt autodiscovery; if prompted, enter your password and approve the MFA push in Microsoft Authenticator (or enter the SMS code).
7. Wait for Outlook to finish configuring the account. When the setup completes, click Finish.
8. Back in the Mail dialog, ensure the newly created profile is selected under "Always use this profile" and click OK.
9. Launch Outlook. Allow it to synchronize your mailbox; this may take several minutes depending on mailbox size and network speed.
10. Test sending and receiving a message, verify search functionality, and confirm that the status bar shows "Connected".

Service Desk Procedure - Rebuilding Outlook Profile

Agents should follow this workflow when a user reports Outlook issues that have not been resolved by preliminary checks. The procedure mirrors the self-help steps but includes additional validation, documentation, and user communication.

1. Greet the user, confirm the symptom(s), and verify that the user can access Outlook on the web (OWA) successfully. If OWA fails, troubleshoot network or account issues before proceeding.
2. Ask the user to close Outlook and verify no Outlook processes are running (Task Manager -> Details -> outlook.exe).
3. Guide the user to open Mail Setup: Win?+?R -> control.exe /name Microsoft.MailAndCalendar -> Enter.
4. In Mail Setup, click Show Profiles..., document the existing profile name, then click Remove and confirm.
5. Click Add..., enter a new profile name (e.g., "Acme-Outlook-[username]"), and click OK.
6. Enter the user's Acme email address, click Connect, and allow Autodiscover to configure the account. Prompt the user to approve MFA via Microsoft Authenticator or provide the SMS code if fallback is used.
7. When the account is added successfully, click Finish, then set the new profile as the default in Mail Setup.
8. Instruct the user to launch Outlook and monitor the synchronization progress. Remind them that the first sync may take 10-30?minutes.
9. After synchronization, ask the user to send a test email, perform a search, and confirm the status bar reads "Connected". Document the outcome in the ticket.
10. If the problem persists, collect logs (Outlook -> File -> Options -> Advanced -> Enable troubleshooting logging) and escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration team per the escalation guidance below.

Verification and Next Steps

Once the profile is rebuilt, verify that all core Outlook functions work: sending/receiving email, calendar access, free/busy lookup, and search. Encourage the user to enable Cached Exchange Mode if they prefer offline work (File -> Account Settings -> Change -> More Settings -> Advanced -> Cached Exchange Mode). Remind the user that their password will expire every 90?days and that they can reset it via the self-service portal at https://passwordreset.acme.example. If the user continues to experience crashes, advise them to disable any third-party COM add-ins permanently or contact the Application Support team for further investigation.

When to escalate

If after rebuilding the profile the user still experiences crashes, disconnection, or repeated password prompts, escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration support group. Include in the escalation: the user's name, employee ID, device model and OS version, a summary of troubleshooting steps already performed (including profile rebuild, OWA test, add-in disable), any error messages captured, and relevant logs (Outlook troubleshooting logs, Event Viewer Application logs). Mark the ticket as P2 High if the user cannot send/receive email; otherwise P3 Moderate.

Keywords: Outlook profile rebuild, Outlook not receiving email, Outlook keeps crashing, Outlook disconnected, Outlook search not working, Outlook password prompt, Mail setup, Show Profiles, COM add-in, Cached Exchange Mode, Password reset, MFA, Microsoft Authenticator, Outlook on the web, OWA